Lead Through It

A Compass for Leadership Transition Intelligence

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The stories in this book are drawn from the author's leadership and coaching practice. Names, identifying details, and circumstances have been changed, and some accounts are composites, to protect confidentiality.

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PART I: THE MAP

Understanding Leadership Transition Intelligence

"It isn't the changes that do you in, it's the transitions."
— William Bridges

Chapter One

What Is Leadership Transition Intelligence?

Leadership has spent decades learning to measure itself. We named cognitive intelligence and built an industry around it. We named emotional intelligence and rewrote leadership development around that. We have language for resilience, for executive presence, for strategic thinking — a sophisticated vocabulary for almost everything we ask of a leader.

We have almost none for how they change.

Not the change on the org chart — the change underneath it: the moment a leader's sense of who they are can no longer keep pace with what they have just been asked to become. This capacity has gone largely unnamed. Not unstudied — transition has been written about for decades — but never named as what it actually is: a distinct, developable leadership intelligence. The capacity to move through the defining identity shifts of a career, again and again, each at a higher altitude, and emerge more coherent, not more fragmented.

Every leader who rises will face these shifts. Almost none are taught to navigate them. That gap is not a personal failing. It is a missing field — and this book is an attempt to name it, map it, and put it in your hands.

Across twenty-five years working with leaders in corporate settings, and more than a decade coaching them through their transitions, I have watched it decide careers. Let me show you what it looks like when it is missing.

"I know I am good at what I do. And that's exactly why I got promoted."

Those were the first words Aria said to me when we sat down together for our first coaching session.

She was not boasting. She was stating a fact — the way a person does when they have spent years building something they can rely on. Aria had a reputation. In her organization, she was known as the fixer. You had a problem, you gave it to Aria. Complexity, ambiguity, impossible deadlines — she moved through them with a clarity that others found almost uncanny. She got things done. She got results. And eventually, she got promoted to be a manager.

And she had no doubt that she could handle it.

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The first week of onboarding was electric. Aria arrived with a full head of ideas, a clear sense of direction, and the quiet confidence of someone who had never met an obstacle she could not outwork. She had already mapped out her strategy: assign tasks clearly, hold people to deadlines, show her team how to do things right. She knew what excellence looked like — she had been living it for years.

Then the first week ended. And the second week began.

And something she could not quite name started to shift.

Two of her new team members — both of whom had competed against her for the very promotion she had just received — were perfectly polite. They showed up. They completed their work. But Aria could feel it: a distance, quiet and growing, like a gap widening between two surfaces that had once been flush. “As long as they do their job, I should be fine,” she told herself. And she pressed forward.

Then one team member fell ill. Three weeks of sick leave. Without hesitating, Aria absorbed his workload. It was temporary, she reasoned. She could cover it. That is what she did — she covered things. She fixed things.

Around the same time, her organization rolled out an AI integration initiative. New technology. New pipelines. Training required across the whole team. Aria leaned in immediately — this was her territory, the domain that had defined her expertise and earned her this

promotion. She was not going to cede that ground. In addition to her organization's training program, she launched herself into an extra trial project involving international teams across Asia. Her evenings, already shortened, now carried a new weight: online calls timed to meet her colleagues during their working hours on the other side of the world.

The mornings became a negotiation. The evenings became a schedule. And somewhere in between, the nightly reading ritual she shared with her three-year-old son quietly shifted shape — until it was her son reading stories aloud to her while she cleaned dishes and packed lunches for the next day, both of them in the same room, each in their own world.

She told herself this was efficiency. That multitasking was one of her strengths. And she had always believed that — because for most of her career, it had been true. What she could not yet see was that what she was calling a strength had become a coping mechanism. She was not managing multiple priorities. She was fragmenting under the weight of an identity that no longer fit the life she was living.

"I wish I had more time," she told me later. "I just don't have enough time."

But time was never the real problem.

A few weeks into this new dynamic, Aria began to notice things. Her focus was fraying. She found herself slower in meetings — struggling to track what her team was saying in ways she had not experienced before. And the two former competitors? They were not updating her on their work the way she expected. One of them, she noticed with growing unease, had become impressively fluent in the new AI tools — so fluent that he had begun communicating directly with her boss on one of the projects.

She wanted to address it. She knew she should address it. But every time she moved toward that conversation, something stopped her. She did not want to make things worse. She did not want to be seen as threatened. She did not want to manage them in a way that exposed how uncertain she had become.

For the first time in her professional life, Aria felt something she did not have a name for.

> ***"I am losing my expert position. And I don't know if I'm actually a good manager."***

"What did I get myself into?"

And then, quieter and more unsettling than anything else: "You are not good enough to be here."

She could not go to her boss — they had promoted her, which meant they trusted her, which meant showing up with problems felt like proof that their trust had been misplaced. She could not tell her team — she was supposed to be leading them. She could not fully admit it to herself.

So she kept going. Exhausted. Isolated. Performing a confidence that was costing her more each day to sustain.

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Does any of this sound familiar?

Not the specific details, perhaps. But the shape of it. The gap between who the room thinks you are and who you feel yourself to be. The moment when the very qualities that earned you the promotion — your drive, your expertise, your capacity to absorb and solve and deliver — become the very things that prevent you from becoming what this next level actually requires.

That gap has a name. And understanding it is the beginning of everything.

The Difference Between Change and Transition

Here is a distinction that leadership culture rarely makes — and that costs leaders quietly, persistently, and sometimes irreversibly.

Change is what happens to you. Transition is who you are becoming through it.

Change is external: the new title, the new team, the new responsibilities, the restructured organization, the expanded scope. Change can happen overnight. A promotion is announced. A role is redefined. A new chapter begins.

Transition is internal. It is the psychological and identity journey that change sets in motion — and it moves at an entirely different pace. It cannot be managed on a timeline. It cannot be achieved through harder work or better strategy. It requires something that high-performing leaders are rarely trained to do: turning inward with honesty, curiosity, and the willingness to let go of who you have been in order to become who this next chapter requires.

The pace of change has made this distinction more urgent than ever. Gartner research found that in 2022 the average employee experienced ten planned enterprise changes — restructurings, culture transformations, replacements of core technology systems — up from just two in 2016. Over the same period, the share of employees willing to support enterprise change fell from 74 percent to 38 percent. Gartner calls this widening gap the "transformation deficit."

Read through William Bridges' lens, the numbers tell a clear story. Organizations have become remarkably good at announcing change. What they have not kept pace with is the transition: the inner work each person must do to let go of the old, move through the uncertainty in between, and commit to the new. Ten changes a year is not ten transitions a year. It is one transition that never gets the chance to finish. And the leader standing in the middle of it is asked to carry their own transition while guiding everyone else through theirs.

Researchers call what Aria experienced role incongruence — the cognitive dissonance that emerges when a leader's self-concept clashes with the demands of a new role. Successful identity transition, the research shows, requires not merely adopting new behaviors, but fundamentally reconceptualizing oneself. It is not a skills gap. It is an identity gap.

KEY CONCEPT

Self-Concept

Self-concept is the evolving internal picture you hold of who you are — shaped by your beliefs, experiences, values, roles, strengths, and limitations. More than self-description, it is the lens through which you interpret yourself and your capacity to act in the world. When a transition unsettles this lens, it is your identity — not your skill set — that the moment is asking you to remake.

I learned this distinction not in a classroom, but in the most quietly humbling moment of my own career.

After twenty-five years moving from technical expert to General Manager — leading teams across countries and industries, earning the credentials, delivering the results — I made the decision to leave corporate and become a full-time leadership coach. On paper, the transition looked clean. I was coaching clients every day. I was building something real. I was doing the work I had prepared for over decades.

But for months, my LinkedIn headline still quietly read: *On sabbatical.*

My own coach noticed. She asked me, gently and directly, why a woman who was coaching leaders full-time was still presenting herself to the world as someone taking a break.

I knew the answer. I just had not let myself say it out loud.

I had changed everything on the outside — my work, my routines, my income, my daily reality. But inside, I was still waiting for permission. Still quietly asking: *Am I allowed to claim this? Have I earned this? Am I enough to be here without the title that used to confirm it?*

I had mastered the external change. But I had not yet made the identity shift.

And that gap — between the role you have stepped into and the identity you have not yet fully inhabited — is precisely where Aria

was standing. Where most leaders stand, at some point, without knowing it.

Why IQ and EQ Aren't Enough

Those two named intelligences each earn their place. IQ (Intelligence Quotient)— the capacity to analyze, strategize, and solve — is table stakes at the senior level, where virtually everyone in the room has it. EQ (Emotional Quotient) — the capacity to understand, manage, and effectively use our emotions, while also recognizing and influencing the emotions of others — has, over two decades, rightly become a cornerstone of leadership development.

But here is what neither IQ nor EQ was designed to address:

The moment when a leader's identity — the story they tell themselves about who they are, what they stand for, and what makes them valuable — is disrupted by a significant transition. When the very self-concept that drove their success — the deeply held belief about who they are and what makes them capable — becomes a source of confusion, fear, or quiet paralysis.

Aria was not struggling because she lacked intelligence. She was one of the sharpest people in her organization. She was not struggling because she lacked emotional awareness. She could read the room, feel the distance growing with her team members, and sense the unease in herself. She was struggling because nobody had given her a map for this particular territory — the psychological and identity terrain of leadership transition.

Imposter feelings are common at exactly these moments. In KPMG's study of more than 700 senior executive women, 75 percent reported having experienced imposter feelings at some point in their careers — and 57 percent said those feelings arose when they took on a new leadership role or rose to the executive level.

Katty Kay and Claire Shipman, whose research in *The Confidence Code* draws on neuroscience and psychology, found that women systematically underestimate their abilities and overestimate their risk of failure during high-stakes moments — not because they lack competence, but because the gap between competence and felt

confidence is wider, and takes longer to close. Kay and Shipman found no evidence that women are innately less capable of confidence. They trace the gap instead to socialization and environment: girls learn early to prize perfection over risk, and women lead in workplaces where their competence is more often doubted and their authority more closely judged. Their most liberating finding: confidence does not precede action. It follows it. The leaders who move through Taking-Off most effectively are not the ones who wait until they feel ready. They are the ones who act — imperfectly, courageously — and let confidence build through the doing.

Harvard psychologist Robert Kegan's research on adult development takes Kay and Shipman's discussion of confidence and felt confidence a step further. For Kegan, leadership advancement often requires a shift to what he calls the self-transforming mind — the capacity to step back from one's own identity and examine it objectively. In Kegan's model, most adults operate from a socialized mind, shaped and steered by the expectations of others. Many leaders develop a self-authoring mind — an internal compass, a script of their own. Far fewer develop the self-transforming mind: the capacity to hold that script at arm's length, question it, and rewrite it when a new chapter demands. This is a developmental capacity that many accomplished leaders have simply never needed to cultivate. Until a significant transition forces the question — a promotion or demotion, a layoff, retirement, or starting something new. We will go deeper into these transitions in later chapters.

Kegan is not alone in seeing adult life as an ongoing developmental journey. A whole field of adult development research has established that growth does not stop in early adulthood: the importance of learning and the way we make meaning can keep evolving across a lifetime.

Jennifer Garvey Berger has shown how that evolution happens on the job — leaders growing in the midst of their real challenges, not apart from them. Bill Torbert, a professor emeritus at Boston College, has mapped the progressively deeper "action logics" from which leaders operate — developmental stages that shape how a leader interprets their environment and reacts under pressure — and shown that movement between them is possible. His work describes a progression through stages he named Opportunist,

Diplomat, Expert, Achiever, Individualist (also called Redefining), Strategist, and Alchemist. The core claim is that most leadership development focuses on skills and behaviors while ignoring the deeper question of *how* a leader makes meaning — and that transformation between action logics, not just competence within one, is what produces genuinely different leadership capacity. This research is the ground this book stands on. What adult development explains in general — that human beings can transform how they make meaning — LTQ names and maps at the specific moments when leadership demands it: the transitions.

Sydney Finkelstein named the expertise trap: the paradox by which deep expertise — the very quality that earned a leader their promotion — becomes the thing that derails them. Sally Helgesen and Marshall Goldsmith found the same pattern from another angle: high-achieving leaders in transition protect what made them exceptional rather than letting it go to make room for who they are becoming.

Aria's story illustrates all of this in motion: Her intelligence was not the problem. Her emotional awareness was not the problem. The problem was that she was being asked, for the first time in her career, to do a fundamentally different job, not just a bigger one. And no one had prepared her for what that difference actually required.

Ronald Heifetz's distinction between technical and adaptive challenges names the trap precisely: technical problems can be solved with existing expertise, but adaptive challenges require the person themselves to change. Adaptive challenges ask more of us than better strategies or stronger skills. They require us to grow beyond the leadership habits that brought us this far, reshaping our mindset, identity, and ways of working so we can meet the demands of a new reality. Heifetz and Linsky go further: the most common reason leadership fails, they argue, is treating adaptive challenges as if they were technical problems. Aria was meeting an adaptive challenge with technical tools — and no amount of skill makes that work.

> ***The leaders who struggle most in transition are not lacking talent. They are lacking a map.***

That is a Leadership Transition Intelligence gap.

Defining LTQ

KEY CONCEPT
Leadership Transition Intelligence

Every significant transition reveals something — the patterns of identity, relationship, and context that were shaping you all along. Leadership Transition Intelligence is the capacity to see those patterns clearly, and to transform them on purpose rather than be shaped by them — emerging as a more coherent and grounded self.

How did Aria see these patterns clearly and transform them?

This is the capability this book set out to name. I call it Leadership Transition Intelligence — LTQ.

> ***A transition reveals the leader you've been — and asks for the leader you're becoming.***

It is not about getting smarter or even more emotionally aware. It is about developing the inner compass that allows you to lead yourself in the direction none of your credentials prepared you to go. And it can be developed — literally. The adult brain remains plastic, rewiring itself through new experience and deliberate practice across a lifetime. When this book says a leader can transform, that is not a metaphor. It is biology.

LTQ is the intelligence that operates in the gap that IQ and EQ do not cover. The inner competence that allows a leader to:

- **Recognize** — when an external change is calling for an internal identity evolution, not just an operational response. To see the transition inside the change before it becomes a crisis.
- **Navigate** — the stages of that internal journey with awareness rather than reaction, so that fear, confusion, and

imposter moments become information rather than derailment.

- **Act** — with intention, making deliberate choices about who they are leading themselves to become, rather than defaulting to familiar behaviors that no longer serve the altitude they are at.



Figure 1.1 — Leadership Transition Intelligence: from a transition event to coherent alignment.

Brené Brown's research on courageous leadership adds an important dimension here. Leaders who navigate transitions most

powerfully are not those who armor up — who perform certainty, suppress self-doubt, and treat vulnerability as a liability. They are what Brown calls daring leaders: those who are willing to be seen in the uncertainty, to lead from coherence rather than performance, and to treat the discomfort of transition as the price of genuine growth. The armored leader gets through the transition. The daring leader is changed by it.

This is the intelligence nobody taught you. Not because it is not important — it may be the most important leadership capacity of all. But because it requires looking inward at a time when the entire culture of high performance is pointing outward.

The Cost of Navigating Without It

Aria's story did not end in crisis. But it could have. And for too many leaders, it does.

Research consistently places the failure or significant underperformance rate for leaders in new roles at between 35 and 47 percent, depending on whether the transition is internal or external. And the most common form of that struggle is not spectacular. It is quiet. Leaders perform on the surface while privately losing ground underneath.

The financial stakes are equally sobering. FranklinCovey estimates that a failed executive transition can cost an organization as much as $2.7 million per leader.

A decade-long study drawing on 2,600 in-depth interviews with Fortune 1000 executives, conducted by the leadership consultancy Navalent and reported by the World Economic Forum, found that 76 percent of new executives said their organization's formal development processes were minimally helpful in preparing them for what they would actually face.

> ***The leaders were not uniquely unprepared. The systems around them were.***

In a 2021 DDI (a leadership consulting firm) study, three-quarters of US leaders — and more than four in five globally — reported

feeling unprepared for their new roles. Not inadequate — unprepared. There is an important difference. These were capable people placed into high-stakes situations without the maps, tools, or support that would have made the difference.

This is not a personal failing. It is a systemic gap — and it is precisely the gap that Leadership Transition Intelligence is designed to close.

The cost is not only professional. It is personal. It is the evenings lost, the mornings that become a struggle, the three-year-old who goes to sleep before his mother feels she can stop working. It is the relationships that quietly deteriorate because a leader cannot yet navigate the new relational terrain they are standing in. It is the voice, growing louder and more insistent, that says: "You are not good enough to be here."

That voice is not the truth. But without a map, it can begin to feel like it is.

The Upward Spiral

Here is what I want you to understand before we go any further.

Leadership transitions are not a problem to be solved. They are not evidence of inadequacy. They are not a detour from your growth — they are the engine of it.

Every significant leadership transition you navigate — with intelligence, with self-awareness, with the willingness to examine not just your strategy but your identity — prepares you for the next level. And there will be a next level. You will move through these stages not once, but many times, at ever-higher altitudes.

The goal of Leadership Transition Intelligence is not to make transitions easier. Some of what this journey asks of you will never be easy. The goal is to make them conscious — so that you are the author of your becoming, rather than a passenger in a process you do not fully understand.

Aria eventually found her way through. She learned to distinguish between the expertise that had brought her to this level and the leadership identity this level was asking her to grow into. She

learned to have the conversations she had been avoiding. She allowed two former competitors to become something closer to allies. She learned to ask for help from her boss not as an admission of failure, but as evidence of growing and the strategic leader she was becoming. And she learned — slowly, imperfectly, with more grace than she gave herself credit for — to inhabit her new identity not as a performance, but as a truth.

That is what Leadership Transition Intelligence looks like in practice.

And that is what this book is designed to help you build.

Reflection Prompts

At the close of each chapter, you will find three prompts — one for each layer of the Coherence Triad: Me, We, and The World. These are not exercises to complete in a sitting. They are invitations to return to. Take them with you.

Me — Identity
Think of a transition you are currently navigating or have recently moved through. Where have you felt the gap between the role you are in and the identity you are reaching for but have not yet fully claimed? What would it mean to close that gap?

We — Relationships
Who in your professional life can see your transition more clearly than you can? What might they notice that you are not yet allowing yourself to see? What would it take to invite that perspective in?

The World — Context and Visibility
Where in your external world — your positioning, your reputation, your professional presence — are you still presenting a version of yourself that belongs to a previous chapter? What would it look like to update that signal?

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The rest of the book

Chapter One names the gap. The rest of Lead Through It maps it: three stages every significant leadership transition moves through — Taking-Off, Cruising, Awakening — and the three layers each stage asks something of. Who you are. Who you are with. The system you lead in.

Nine positions in all. The framework's usefulness is not that it predicts exactly where you are. It is that it gives you language for what you are experiencing.

Find your stage
The LTQ Self-Assessment is eighteen questions and takes about six minutes. You will finish knowing which stage is most active for you, which layer is most activated within it, and what that position is asking of you. It shows where you are now, not what you are capable of — your capacity is what you build next.

leadershiptransitionintelligence.com/assessment.html

Thank you for reading early
You are reading this before almost anyone else, and that matters to me. If something in it lands — or does not — I would genuinely like to know. You can reply to the email this came in, or find me at leadershiptransitionintelligence.com.

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Wherever you are on the map — Taking-Off, Cruising, or Awakening — I hope you lead through it.

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